

Caleb H. Kelley, Ph.D.

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Last updated: May 2026

🎓 EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Romance Languages

August 2017 – August 2024

The University of Alabama

Tuscaloosa, AL

– **Dissertation:** *Sounding gay and straight in Seville: A variationist perspective on persona and syllable-final /s/ realization*

– **Advisor:** Dr. Erin O'Rourke

M.A. in Romance Languages

August 2015 – May 2017

The University of Alabama

Tuscaloosa, AL

B.A. in Spanish

August 2010 – December 2013

University of Alabama at Birmingham

Birmingham, AL

B.S. in Biology

August 2010 – December 2013

University of Alabama at Birmingham

Birmingham, AL

🔍 RESEARCH INTERESTS

My research examines how speakers use phonetic variation to construct and interpret socially meaningful personae in Spanish-speaking contexts, drawing on acoustic analysis, perception experiments, and computational modeling within a sociophonetic and third-wave variationist framework.

Keywords: Hispanic linguistics; phonetics and phonology; sociolinguistics; language variation and change; dialectology; quantitative/experimental methodology; sociophonetic perception; second language acquisition; listener interpretation; language attitudes and ideologies; educational technology; second dialect acquisition; machine learning

💼 EMPLOYMENT

Visiting Assistant Professor

2024 – present

Department of Spanish and Portuguese, Emory University

Atlanta, GA

Graduate Teaching Assistant/Instructor of Record

2015 – 2024

Department of Modern Languages and Classics, The University of Alabama

Tuscaloosa, AL

Adjunct Instructor of Spanish

2021 – 2022

Department of English and World Languages, University of Montevallo

Montevallo, AL

PUBLICATIONS

Manuscripts in Preparation

Kelley, C. H. (in prep). Prosodic identity performance in Sevillian Spanish: A mixed-effects analysis of gay and straight vocal personae. Target: *Journal of Language and Sexuality*.

Kelley, C. H. (in prep). Vowel space and performed identity in male Sevillian speech. Target: *Spanish in Context*.

RESEARCH PROJECTS IN PROGRESS

Sociophonetic Perception of Sexual Identity: Evidence From Native and Non-Native Spanish Speakers

- Employs a matched-guise methodology to test bilingual perception of sexual identity markers in Spanish.
- Status: Data collection in progress (Spring & Summer 2026).

Supervised Classification of Sociophonetic Identity Markers in Sevillian Spanish Persona Production

- Applies machine learning classification (Random Forest, SVM) to acoustic features to determine which segmental and prosodic cues most reliably predict performed vocal personae.
- Status: Analysis of controlled persona-switching corpus.

PRESENTATIONS

Invited Talks

(2026, March 11). *From Production to Perception: Designing a Sociophonetic Study*, Department of Modern Languages and Classics, The University of Alabama, Tuscaloosa, AL.

(2020, November). *Foundations of Spanish Phonetics and Phonology*, Guest Lecture for SP 383: Linguistic Fundamentals of the Spanish Language, University of Alabama, Tuscaloosa, AL.

Peer Reviewed Conference Presentations

Kelley, C. H. (2026). Modeling prosodic variation in Spanish gay and straight personae. *Southeastern Conference on Linguistics (SECOL) 2026*, Atlanta, GA. [accepted; not presented]

Kelley, C. H. (2024). Phonetic dimensions of gay-sounding speech in Spanish: Syllable-final /s/ variation and persona performance. *Linguistics Conference at the University of Georgia (LCUGA) 2024*, University of Georgia, Athens, GA.

Kelley, C. H. (2023). Analyzing the phonetic performance of male sexuality in Sevillian Spanish through remote data collection. *New Ways of Analyzing Variation (NwAV) 51*, Queens College, Flushing, NY.

Kelley, C. H. (2023). Analyzing the performance of male sexuality in Spanish through remote data collection and digital corpus analysis. *Congreso Internacional de Lingüística Digital (CILiDi) 2*, Universidad de Alicante, Alicante, Spain.

Kelley, C. H. (2023). Syllable-final /s/ and the sociolinguistic construction of personae in Spanish speakers. *OSU Congress on Hispanic and Lusophone Linguistics Symposium (OSUCHiLL) 27*, The Ohio State University, Columbus, OH.

Kelley, C. H. (2023). Using sociolinguistic personae to analyze phonetic variation among gay and non-gay Spanish speakers. *University of Alabama Languages Conference (UALC)*, The University of Alabama, Tuscaloosa, AL.

Kelley, C. H. (2022). A pilot study investigating sociophonetic variation among LGBTQ+ speakers in Peninsular Spanish. *University of Alabama Languages Conference (UALC)*, The University of Alabama, Tuscaloosa, AL.

Kelley, C. H. (2021). Sounding queer in Spain: A sociophonetic analysis of production and perception. *Lavender Languages & Linguistics 27*, California Institute of Integral Studies, San Francisco, CA.

Kelley, C. H. (2020). Sounding gay and straight in Granada, Spain: Sociophonetic evidence from production and perception. *Lavender Languages & Linguistics* 27, California Institute of Integral Studies, San Francisco, CA [accepted; postponed due to COVID-19 pandemic].

Jacobson, S., & **Kelley, C. H.** (2020). Very? Much!: A corpus analysis of alternation between “muy” and “mucho” in Spanish. *10th International Workshop on Spanish Sociolinguistics*, Georgia Institute of Technology, Atlanta, GA [accepted; canceled due to COVID-19 pandemic].

Jacobson, S., & **Kelley, C. H.** (2017). “To be” or “to not be”: Attitudes and behaviors toward the split infinitive in English. *8th International Contrastive Linguistics Conference*, National and Kapodistrian University of Athens, Athens, Greece.

Kelley, C. H. (2016). The Madre María de San José (1656–1719) Project. *Digitarium: University of Alabama Digital Humanities Conference*, The University of Alabama, Tuscaloosa, AL.

Kelley, C. H. (2016). Null and overt subject pronouns in Madrid and Caracas with verbs of external activity: A corpus study. *Linguistics Conference at the University of Georgia (LCUGA) 3*, University of Georgia, Athens, GA.

Peer Reviewed Poster Presentations

Kelley, C. H. (2025). Prosodic identity performance in Spanish: A mixed-effects analysis of gay and straight vocal personae. *Hispanic Linguistics Symposium (HLS) 2025*, University of Arizona, Tucson, AZ [accepted; not presented].

Kelley, C. H. (2022). Performing sexual orientation in Spanish: A pilot study investigating persona and syllable-final /s/ realization. *10th Workshop on Spanish Sociolinguistics (WSS10)*, University of Georgia, Athens, GA.

Kelley, C. H. (2016). Null and overt subject pronouns in Madrid and Caracas with verbs of external activity: A corpus study. *Quantitative Methods in Linguistics Research Showcase*, The University of Alabama, Tuscaloosa, AL.

FUNDING

Research Support

Research support awards (4)

2021 – 2024

\$2,025 total, UA Graduate School/Modern Languages and Classics

Conference Travel

Conference funding and travel awards (6)

2017 – 2023

\$4,262 total, UA Graduate School/Modern Languages and Classics; UA Capstone International

External Applications

Lewis and Clark Fund for Exploration and Field Research

2022, 2023

American Philosophical Society (not funded)

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

At Emory University

Visiting Assistant Professor

2024 – present

SPAN 101, 102, 201, 202, 212

At The University of Alabama

Graduate Instructor of Record

SP 101, 102, 103, 201, 202, 353, 356 (including online sections)

2015 – 2024

Course Design Collaboration with Dr. Bryan Koronkiewicz

SP 383: Linguistic Fundamentals of the Spanish Language

At University of Montevallo

Adjunct Instructor

SPN 101, 102, 201

2021 – 2022

SERVICE

To the Profession

Linguistic Society of America Committee on LGBTQ+ [Z] Issues in Linguistics (COZIL)

2023 – 2024

Member

Abstract Reviewer

2017 – 2022

University of Alabama Languages Conference (UALC)

To the Department and University

Spanish 102 Coordinator

2020 – 2022

Spanish Basic Language Program, Department of Modern Languages and Classics, UA (43 sections)

Graduate Student Representative

2021 – 2022

Department of Modern Languages and Classics, UA

LengUA Lab Graduate Student Co-director

2020 – 2021

UA (Linguistics research group)

LengUA Lab Member

2016 – 2024

UA

Conference Organization

Committee Member, UALC

2021 – 2022

University of Alabama Languages Conference

IT Committee Member, UALC

2020 – 2021

University of Alabama Languages Conference

Registration Chair, UALC

2018 – 2019

University of Alabama Languages Conference

Vice President/Program Chair, UALC

2017 – 2018

University of Alabama Languages Conference

Student Organizations and Community Outreach

Vice President, La Última Letra
UA

2018 – 2019

Secretary, La Última Letra
UA

2016 – 2017

Event Judge, Convención de la Federación de los Círculos de Español de Alabama

2015 – 2020

Mentoring

Jim Moore

Spring 2021

Team teaching assistant and mentee for SP 102 course, UA

Katie Cauley

Fall 2020

Team teaching assistant and mentee for SP 102 course, UA

Jordyn Battistelli

Fall 2019

Team teaching assistant and mentee for SP 201 course, UA

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

Dissertation Summer Writing Challenge, The University of Alabama. Summer 2022.

David Bauer Grant Writing Workshop, The University of Alabama. Fall 2021.

Writing for Academic Publication, Advanced Seminar (CSE 690), The University of Alabama. Spring 2019.

Online Teaching Certification, The University of Alabama. 2016 – 2024.

Spanish Language Immersion Program, Middlebury Language Schools, Middlebury, VT. Summer 2014.

Study Abroad in Jaén, Spain, University of Alabama at Birmingham and Universidad de Jaén. Summer 2011.

MEMBERSHIPS, LANGUAGES, & TECHNICAL SKILLS

Memberships Linguistics Society of America (LSA) • Acoustical Society of America (ASA) • Alabama World Languages Association (AWLA) • Sigma Delta Pi (Omicron Mu Chapter)

Languages English (native) • Spanish (near-native) • French (intermediate)

Programming R • Python • HTML/CSS • $\LaTeX$ • Bash/Unix • PRAAT

Software Microsoft Office 365 • Adobe Creative Suite • Qualtrics • RStudio • SPSS • PRAAT • Audacity • Montreal Forced Aligner • ELAN • Zotero • EndNote

Platforms Canvas • Blackboard • LingroLearning • VHL Central • Google Drive • Box

References available upon request.